and polyglot world of Marrakesh… with its Berbers, Arabs, Sephardic Jews, Africans, Moriscos and Christians' would have come as a great shock.

In the sixteenth century in Fatehpur Sikri, there was a similar shearing of ideas and languages and influences between men and women from all over the Mughal Empire, 100-million strong at its peak,* and boasting thirty languages and seven religions, and from further still, from the Deccan, Persia, and from the shores of Christendom. In an equally cosmopolitan court, a new culture would be wrought which would travel, through its great courtiers, in syncopated rhythms, vernacular cadences, and jewel-bright colours, to all corners of the empire.

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*Ali Adil Shah's predecessor, Ibrahim Adil Shah I, a Sunni, became infamous for his particularly intolerant and cruel rule. He dismissed all his Shia aristocrats and, according to Manu Pillai (see *Rebel Sultans*), indulged in a two-month reign of terror, assassinating Hindus and Muslim officials of rank.

*An alloy of a precious metal with a majority base metal content.

*A millennial sect.

*W. H. Moreland's estimate; Shireen Moosvi's estimate is 130-140 million. Historians such as Sanjay Subrahmanyam and Ashok V. Desai consider this inflated.